

drawback—the keys feel a bit mushy, and you tend to miss a keystroke or two. Also, the SSD-KB-880 has poor build quality, with rubber buttons for hotkeys without proper legends—easily avoidable.

On the ergonomics front, the Genius KB-12e has much better design than the competition. Though the keys have a soft feel, they offer good tactile feedback, something completely lacking in the other Genius keyboards. The Genius Luxemate scroll has a laptop-type keyboard, not enough spacing between keys, is cramped, and there's a general lack of tactile feedback. The Genius KB-06X, despite being an entry-level keyboard, offers better ergonomics compared to its older sibling, the KB-12e.

Microsoft's Comfort Curve 2000 quite doesn't feel like a Microsoft keyboard. The keys are nicely arranged on a curve for stress-free typing, but are simply too soft and offer no resistance to keystrokes, thus affecting feedback. Apart from this, this keyboard is a wonderful device.

The Zebronic ZEB-K500L has a weird key layout: the [Home], [Page Up], etc., key group is lined up with [Backspace], [Enter], etc., and this leads to mistakes. Very often, when trying to hit [Backspace], you might hit [Home], which can get quite frustrating. Similarly, the [Delete] and [Insert] keys are placed on the bottom row near the Windows key—not easy to reach. Also, since the keyboard has a laptop keyboard feel, tactile feedback is hampered.

Our Verdict

Ideally speaking, Logitech's G5 shouldn't have been featured in this category, but our categorisation criteria dictated that it should. The G5 has fantastic build quality that's seldom seen on a keyboard, and has many features.

Though Logitech has priced the G5 ambitiously, we think the price is a little too high, but not atrociously so—considering the features it offers. The keyboard is a must-have for those who play a lot of RTS games; if you don't, you can afford to look at other keyboards!

Now, out of the rest of the keyboards, iBall's Power Key



TECH-COM SSD-KB-990

Designer comes out tops due to its truckload of features and decent ergonomics. Logitech's Standard keyboard and Tech-Com's SSD-KB-990 tie for second place. If you are on a shoestring budget and want a no-frills keyboard, Logitech's Standard keyboard is the way to go. If loads of one-touch hotkeys is what you want, Tech-Com's SSD-KB-990 is the keyboard to opt for—remember, however, that it's a shade below Logitech's Standard keyboard in terms of ergonomics.

COMBOS

A combo kit is essentially a keyboard and a mouse bundled into a single package. This trend started about a year and a half ago, and the apparent success has motivated every vendor to have a combo kit in their product line-up.

The entry-level kits, due to price constraints, are wired models, whereas the top-end combos are wireless. Of the 15 combo sets we reviewed, five were wired and the rest were cordless. Let's take a closer look at what they offer.

WIRED DESKTOP COMBOS

Features

Most of the wired combos are targeted at entry-level buyers, and hence are anaemic on features. One good thing, though, was the inclusion of optical mice in all the combos—this does away with the routine maintenance problems that plague ball mice.

The first advantage of buying a combo is that you get an aesthetically matched set that looks nice on your desk. As far as looks go, Gigabyte's GKM-10 and Genius EasyTouch Optical II look great in their dual-tone White

and Blue combination. Logitech has gone for an all-black combo, and should complement a black monitor and cabinet system. Zebronic's 911 combo is targeted at gamers; however, the golden black camouflage design with a printed Counter Strike theme makes it look gaudy.

Except for Gigabyte's GK-6PB, all the keyboards offered some extra keys. Logitech's Internet Pro Desktop, Zebronic's 911 combo and Genius' Easy Touch Optical II offered multimedia keys that can launch the default media player, play songs, and perform other functions.

Except for Gigabyte's GK-6PB—a standard keyboard—all the others had one-touch keys for launching Internet Explorer, the default e-mail client such as Outlook Express, and buttons for going back and forth while navigating the Web.

Genius' Easy Touch Optical II has gone a step forward and also offered one-touch keys for accessing My Computer, Calculator, and for putting the machine to sleep.

A palm-rest on a keyboard relieves a lot of wrist stress, and our advice is to buy a keyboard with one. While it is not the only thing to look for in terms of ergonomics, it does help.

Except for the Zebronic 911, all the other keyboards came with a palm rest. Gigabyte's GKM-10 featured a non-detachable palm rest, which is both good and bad—good because it will stay firm and won't move about like the detachable ones do, and bad because if you have a cramped desktop, this will hurt more than help.

The mice that came bundled with these combo sets were standard three-button optical devices. Logitech's offering delighted us with its ambidextrous design and precise track-



Genius EasyTouch Optical II